There is a simple driver modification which when done allows PhysX to be run on AMD cards as well, though it is not officially and never will be supported by NVIDIA. Generally you have the CPU handling the PhysX calculations but with NVIDIA cards in SLI you can have a dedicated PhysX card. And that too you don't need to follow the SLI compatibility rules. Any previous generation NVIDIA card which has PhysX support will do. The whole prospect of buying an extra graphics card just for PhysX is merely wasting money. You'd be better off having two equally powerful cards in SLI than having an older card as the dedicated PhysX card.

Workstations

Both manufacturers have specialised cards for workstations. These cards are for CAD software and other 3D modelling and animating software as these cards don't have the technology that is otherwise useful in running games. You can play games on these cards but you'd be better off using a normal desktop card for that purpose. NVIDIA's Quadro series and AMD's FirePro are both better suited for CAD and other modelling software.

NVIDIA CUDA and AMD APP

CUDA (Compute Unified Device Architecture) and APP (Accelerated Parallel Processing) are API's for running programs on NVIDIA and AMD cards respectively. Graphics cards are designed to process a huge volume of calculations using parallel processing. Using these two API's programmers can make applications that can harness the immense computing capability of a graphics card.

What to buy

When shopping for a graphics card remember the following.

1. The generation of the GPU, the core frequency and the number of CUDA cores/stream processors it has should be given more priority over the amount of RAM it has.
2. For playing simple games you don't need the latest graphics card it is the AAA titles that would probably tax your graphics processor. Get the latest card only if you wish to play the most latest games at the maximum possible settings.
3. Certain SLI configurations can leave a port or two unusable, so be cau-